

PROCESS

How to Choose the Right Brand Agency

The questions to ask, the signals to look for, and the mistakes to avoid when selecting a brand partner.

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Choosing a brand agency is one of the highest-stakes vendor decisions a company makes. Get it right and the relationship compounds — producing better work and better outcomes each time. Get it wrong and you've spent budget on something that doesn't move your business.

■ Start with the work, not the credentials

Before reviewing proposals or attending presentations, look at the agency's actual output. Portfolio work tells you more than any pitch document. Ask yourself: is the work genuinely distinctive, or does it look like a polished version of whatever's trending? Does it reflect strategic thinking, or is it visual craft without visible reasoning?

■ The team question is the most important one

Agency pitches are often presented by senior partners who will have limited involvement in your actual project. Ask directly: who will work day-to-day on this project?

- ☐ Who specifically will be working on my project?
- ☐ What percentage of the lead creative director's time is on my project?
- ☐ Have I met everyone who will be on the team?
- ☐ What's the typical senior-to-junior ratio on a project like this?

■ Strategy vs. execution: understand what you're buying

Some agencies are strong strategists who produce competent creative. Some are exceptional craftspeople with limited strategic depth. Some do both well. Be clear on which you need.

■ References are non-negotiable

Always speak to at least two previous clients — ideally clients who worked on a project similar in scope to yours. The questions that matter most: did the agency deliver on time and on budget? How did they handle disagreements? Would you hire them again?

■ Red flags to watch for

Not all red flags are obvious. Here are the ones that experienced clients recognise most often.

- ☐ Presenting speculative creative in the pitch — agencies that show concepts without a brief are showing what impresses prospects, not what they'd produce for your specific brief
 - ☐ Vague scope of work in the contract with hourly rate overages for anything not explicitly listed
 - ☐ IP ownership that's ambiguous or unfavourable — you should own the final brand assets outright
 - ☐ No evidence of their strategic process, only portfolio images
 - ☐ Extreme underprice — brand work that seems like a bargain often is one, for the wrong reasons
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| The engagement model question

Agencies typically offer project-based or retainer-based engagements. A project is right for defined, scoped work. A retainer is right for ongoing creative partnership. Ask the agency what they recommend for your situation and why.

| The price question

Brand work that's right for your company should neither be the most expensive agency you could find nor the cheapest. The right question is not "what does it cost?" but "what does it cost relative to the impact it will have?"
